already been sent to Bharat had done nothing by way of actual conversion and that ‘idol worshippers’ had made rapid progress under the auspices of ‘Christian rulers’.

This was followed by a fairly detailed speech by Thomas Babington Macaulay on the same day, who touched upon a host of issues, including on the need for consolidation and codification of laws in Bharat, comparing its diversity with that of Europe. Apart from citing the need for uniformity in laws and legal outcomes, the approach to indigenous societal structures and the demonisation of the ‘caste’ system as well as Brahmins may be traced to Macaulay to a significant extent. Critically, he made no bones of the fact that the spread of European civilisation in the East would benefit Britain from the standpoint of governance since Europeanisation of the native population would bridge the cultural gap and make governance and assimilation less cumbersome. In addition to highlighting the practicality and commercial sense behind this approach, this position was couched in moral righteousness befitting the coloniser’s coloniality. Following are a few relevant extracts from his speech that attest to this:

> Having given to the Government supreme legislative power, we next propose to give to it for a time the assistance of a commission for the purpose of digesting and reforming the laws of India, so that those laws may, as soon as possible, be formed into a Code. *Gentleman of whom I wish to speak with the highest respect have expressed a doubt whether India be at present in a fit state to receive a benefit which is not yet enjoyed by this free and highly civilised country.* Sir, I can allow to this argument very little weight beyond that which it derives from the personal authority of those who use it. *For, in the first place, our freedom and our high civilisation make this improvement, desirable as it must always be, less indispensably necessary to us than to our Indian subjects; and in the next place, our freedom and civilisation, I fear, make it far more difficult for us to obtain this benefit for ourselves than to bestow it on them.*
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> I believe that no country ever stood so much in need of a code of laws as India; and I believe also that there never was a country in which the want might so easily be supplied. I said that there were many points of analogy between the state of that country after the fall of the Mogul power, and the state of Europe after the fall of the Roman